

CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

1.1 BACKGROUND

Mythology has always been an integral part of human civilization, shaping cultural beliefs, traditions, and societal values. Every great civilization—whether Egyptian, Roman, Greek, Indian, or Chinese—has developed its own rich collection of myths, folklores, and religious narratives. Among these, Indian mythology stands out as one of the most profound and diverse, with its roots deeply embedded in ancient texts such as the Vedas, Upanishads, Puranas, and epics like the *Ramayana* and *Mahabharata*. These stories not only provide moral and philosophical teachings but also offer a glimpse into historical events, societal structures, and human interactions.

In contemporary Indian literature, mythological retelling plays a crucial role in keeping these age-old narratives relevant. Writers like Amish Tripathi, Sudha Murty, Ashok Banker, and Ashwin Sanghi have introduced fresh perspectives on the ancient epics, blending mythology with modern themes, history, and philosophy.

Through this research, we are going to contribute to the growing field of mythological studies in the Indian English Literature and examines how such retelling reshape the public perception of timeless epics. Many contemporary authors like Amish Tripathi, Sudha Murty, Devdutt Pattnaik, Ashwin Sanghi, Anand Neelakantan, Kavita Kane and others have re-imagined mythology in unique way, enriching the literary landscape with fresh perspectives, interpretation and with deeper insights. Their works highlight the dynamic nature of mythology and its relevance in today's world.

1.2 INTRODUCTION TO THE AUTHOR

Sudha Murty is a famous Indian writer, teacher, and social worker. She was born on 19th August 1950 in Shiggaon, Karnataka. From childhood, she loved reading books and

listening to stories from her family. These early experiences later inspired her to become a storyteller.

She studied engineering and became one of the first women engineers to work in a big company in India, TELCO (now Tata Motors). Later, she focused more on social service and became the chairperson of the Infosys Foundation. Through this work, she helped poor people by supporting schools, hospitals, libraries, and disaster relief across India.

Sudha Murty is also a popular author who writes in simple and clear language. Her books teach moral values like kindness, honesty, humility, and respect for others. Many of her stories are based on real-life experiences, Indian culture, and mythology. Some of her well-known books are *Wise and Otherwise*, *Grandma's Bag of Stories*, and *The Day I Stopped Drinking Milk*.

She has received major honours such as the Padma Shri and Padma Bhushan. Sudha Murty is respected for her simplicity, humanity, and contribution to literature and society

1.3 AIMS AND OBJECTIVES

- a) To study how Sudha Murty reimagines divine characters by presenting gods with human emotions, strengths, weaknesses, and moral struggles.
- b) To examine how the humanization of divine figures challenges or reshapes traditional religious perceptions in a modern context.
- c) To analyse the portrayal of women in the selected texts and evaluate their role as strong, confident, and central figures in the narratives.
- d) To explore how the author uses simple, clear, and accessible language to make mythological themes understandable and relatable for contemporary readers.
- e) To identify and interpret the moral values and ethical lessons embedded in the stories and understand their relevance in present-day social and cultural life

1.4 METHODOLOGY

The research will undertake a analysis of Sudha Murty's *The Man from the Egg, The Sage with Two Horns, Daughter from the wishing tree*, using an analytical approach. The study will employ descriptive and interpretative methods to explore the mythological reinterpretation within these texts. A close reading of the novels will be conducted to gain a comprehensive understanding of their themes, plot, and character portrayal.

Additionally, this research will be grounded in an extensive in view of literature, which is fundamental to qualitative research. Information is gathered from libraries, academic journals, and credible web sources to ensure a well-rounded and informed analysis.

1.5 LITERATURE REVIEW

Mythological retelling has become an important trend in contemporary Indian English literature. Many modern writers have revisited ancient epics and Puranic stories to make them more relevant to present society. Authors such as Amish Tripathi, Devdutt Pattanaik, Ashwin Sanghi, Anand Neelakantan, and Kavita Kane have reinterpreted mythological narratives from new perspectives. Their works often blend mythology with history, fiction, and modern philosophical ideas.

Scholars have also attempted to explain the nature and function of myths in society. According to Devdutt Pattanaik in *Myth = Mithya*, mythology is not merely a collection of ancient stories but a reflection of cultural beliefs, values, and human imagination. Myths help societies interpret the world, human behaviour, and moral principles. Pattanaik further explains that myths are symbolic narratives that communicate philosophical meanings rather than literal historical truths. They reveal how different cultures interpret concepts such as duty, power, and morality. The book also highlights that myths are continuously reinterpreted across generations, as each retelling adapts traditional narratives to the needs and understanding of contemporary society. These ideas provide a theoretical framework for understanding how mythology functions as a cultural narrative and why modern writers reinterpret mythological stories in new ways.

Contemporary writers have played an important role in reimagining mythological narratives for modern readers. Amish Tripathi, in works such as *The Immortals of Meluha* from The Shiva Trilogy, presents mythological figures as extraordinary human beings whose actions shape their destiny and later lead them to be regarded as divine. By presenting gods in a humanized form, Tripathi makes mythological stories more accessible and relatable to contemporary audiences. Similarly, Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni reinterprets Indian mythology from alternative perspectives. In her novel *The Palace of Illusions*, she narrates the story of the Mahabharata from the viewpoint of Draupadi, highlighting the emotional experiences and inner conflicts of female characters. Such reinterpretations emphasize the importance of revisiting traditional narratives to bring forward voices that were less prominent in earlier versions.

The universal significance of myths has also been discussed by scholars such as Joseph Campbell. In his influential work *The Hero with a Thousand Faces*, Campbell explains that myths from different cultures share similar narrative patterns, particularly the idea of the “Hero’s Journey.” According to him, mythological heroes typically undergo a process of departure, trials, transformation, and return. This journey symbolizes personal growth and the search for meaning in human life. Campbell’s theory suggests that myths continue to remain relevant because they reflect universal human experiences and moral values that transcend cultural boundaries.

Sudha Murty’s contribution to mythological retelling is distinct in its simplicity and moral focus. Unlike other authors who may dramatize or fictionalize mythology extensively, she remains closer to the original narratives while presenting them in clear and accessible language. Her storytelling style is direct and suitable for young and general readers. She removes complex theological explanations and instead emphasizes ethical values, human emotions, and social relevance.

Scholars observe that modern retellings play an important role in keeping mythology alive in contemporary times. They bridge the gap between ancient scriptures and modern readers. In this context, Sudha Murty’s works stand out because she balances tradition and

modernity. Her retellings humanize divine characters, highlight the importance of women, and present universal values such as humility, equality, kindness, and responsibility.

Thus, existing literature shows that mythological reinterpretation is a growing field in Indian English literature, and Sudha Murty's works contribute significantly to making mythology relatable, inclusive, and meaningful for today's generation.

1.6 SCOPE AND LIMITATION OF THE PROJECT

The project studies three selected books by Sudha Murty- *The Man from the Egg*, *The Sage with Two Horns*, *Daughter from the Wishing Tree*- to explore the retelling of Indian mythological narratives and the representation of divine figures, values and cultural traditions. The study focuses on major and thematically significant stories from each text to understand their moral and social relevance. However, due to prescribed page limit, not all narratives have been analyzed in detail, and a few stories have been selectively omitted.

CHAPTER 2: SUMMARY OF THE MAN FROM THE EGG

The Man from the Egg by Sudha Murty is a collection of 24 mythological stories. The book is divided into three sections; The 1st section is *Omkara Swarupa*, contain 2 stories of Brahma; The 2nd section is *Satyam Shivam Sundaram* consist of nine stories about Shiva and Parvati, and the last 3rd section is *Sambhavami Yuge Yuge* contain thirteen stories of Vishnu. All together this book possesses 24 stories drawn from Hindu tradition that highlight the roles of The Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva, the trinity, portrays the ancient myths in a simple narrative style and focusing on moral values, human emotion and the harmony in the universe. Instead of showing god as a perfect and flawless being, the stories highlights how gods makes mistake being a powerful entity. The book also explains how creation, preservation and destruction work together to maintain balance in the world.

The book commences by laying emphasis on the importance of the Trinity. Brahma being the creator who brings life into existence, Vishnu is the preserver who guard righteousness, and the Shiva is the destroying force who helps to rejuvenate new life. These three forces are equally important, and the universe cannot survive without balance among them. The stories are as follows:

2.1 OMKARA SWARUPA

2.1.1 Brahma's Folly: Kamdeva and his wife Rati try to please Brahma. They ask for a magical bow arrow that can make anyone fall in love instantly. Brahma grants the boon. And Kamdeva and Rati use it against him. So Brahma create a beautiful woman name Shatarupa. He becomes so possessive about her that he keeps uses his all heads to keep watch on her. Which make shiva angry and cuts Brahma's on head and curse him that he will be less worshiped.

Analysis: This story shows that pride and uncontrolled desire can destroy wisdom, and even gods must face consequences for their actions.

2.1.2 A Celestial Solution: Another story where Brahman grants two brothers a boon of immortality and only they can kill each other. Once the boon start working, they become too arrogant and start troubling other. This makes Brahma angry and he creates a maiden name Tilottama, whose beauty causes them to fight and kill each other.

Analysis: This story shows that arrogance destroys people, and pride after gaining power always leads to downfall and self-destruction.

2.2 SATYAM SHIVAM SUNDARAM

2.2.1 The Story of Sati: Sati's father, King Daksha, vehemently disapproved of her marriage to Lord Shiva due to Shiva's ascetic lifestyle. Tensions peaked at a grand Yagna when Shiva refused to stand for Daksha, which the king viewed as a deliberate insult. In retaliation, Daksha organized a grander Yagna, deliberately excluding Shiva and Sati. Ignoring Shiva's warnings about her father's harsh words, Sati attended uninvited. After facing public humiliation and abusive language directed at her husband, a regretful Sati plunged into the sacrificial fire, ending her life. Consumed by fury, Shiva began the destructive Tandav dance and sent the fierce Virabhadra to sever Daksha's head. Once his rage subsided, a merciful Shiva revived Daksha with a goat's head. Humbled, Daksha vowed to worship Shiva, who then retreated into deep meditation.

Analysis: This narrative contrasts worldly pride with divine detachment. Daksha's obsession with social hierarchy blinds him to Shiva's true nature, leading to catastrophic consequences. Sati's tragic end highlights the painful intersection of filial duty and marital devotion. Ultimately, the story illustrates the destructive magnitude of divine wrath, balanced closely by profound mercy.

2.2.2 The Birth OF Parvati: The demon Tarakasur secured a boon from Lord Brahma that he could only be killed by Lord Shiva's son. Believing Shiva would never remarry after Sati's death, Tarakasur and his cruel generals unleashed a reign of terror. Responding to pleas, Lord Vishnu prophesied that a son born to Shiva and Parvati would end the tyranny. Meanwhile, Queen Menaka and King Himavat gave birth to Parvati, destined to be Sati reborn. Devoted entirely to Shiva, Parvati rejected all suitors and traveled to Kailash to serve the meditating god. As years passed without Shiva awakening, the

anxious gods realized Tarakasur's reign would continue indefinitely. They sought Lord Vishnu's diplomatic intervention to guarantee the marriage.

Analysis: This chapter emphasizes the themes of reincarnation and cosmic destiny. Tarakasur's fatal flaw is his reliance on a loophole, arrogant in his assumption that Shiva's grief is permanent. Parvati's character is defined by her unwavering, patient devotion, standing in stark contrast to the urgent anxiety of the gods

2.2.3 The Indian Cupid: Lord Vishnu commands his son, Manmatha, and his wife, Rati, to break Lord Shiva's deep meditation. Despite Manmatha's terror of Shiva's apocalyptic Tandav dance, Vishnu insists it is their cosmic duty to ensure the birth of Shiva's son to defeat Tarakasur. Manmatha journeys to Mount Kailash and shoots Shiva with a magical flower arrow guaranteed to induce love. When Shiva's eyes open in wrath, Manmatha mistakenly smiles. This incenses Shiva, who unleashes his legendary third eye, instantly reducing Manmatha to ashes. While Parvati vows to perform rigorous penance, Vishnu comforts the grieving Rati by resurrecting Manmatha as an invisible spirit, Manoj or Ananga, forever residing within human thought.

Analysis: The tale explores the heavy cost of divine duty and self-sacrifice for the greater good. Manmatha's physical destruction and subsequent invisible resurrection serve as an allegory for love itself—transforming it from a physical entity into a powerful, bodiless force of the mind.

2.2.4 A Match Made in Heaven: Parvati undertakes a grueling penance to win Lord Shiva's heart, earning the title Aparna by refusing to eat even a single leaf. Recognizing her spiritual power, Shiva disguises himself as a wandering Sanyasi to test her resolve. The ascetic mocks Shiva as a wrathful hermit who smears himself with ash and wears garlands of skulls. Furious, Parvati fiercely defends Shiva's kindness and decides to walk away. At that moment, Shiva sheds his disguise, recognizes her as Dakshayani, and asks for her hand in marriage. They welcome a six-faced son, Kartikeya, who intimately understands his divine destiny. Fulfilling the prophecy, he vanquishes Tarakasur and his brothers, forever ending the demons' cruel reign.

Analysis: Parvati's severe penance proves that true devotion looks past superficial appearances to love the divine essence. The birth of Kartikeya and his subsequent victory over Tarakasur represents the restoration of universal balance, fulfilling the prophecies set in motion in earlier chapters.

2.2.5 The Moon and the Leaf

2.2.5.1 The Origin of the Crescent Moon: Chandra, the moon god born three times, surfaced during the cosmic ocean churning alongside Goddess Laxmi. Chandra heavily favored his fourth wife, Rohini, prompting his other 26 wives to complain to their father, Daksha, who cursed Chandra's brilliance to deteriorate daily. The wives instantly regretted this, and Daksha sent Chandra to Lord Shiva for help. Shiva softened the curse into a cycle of waxing (Shukla Paksha) and waning (Krishna Paksha). Shiva compassionately placed Chandra upon his own head to comfort him, becoming Chandrasekhara.

Analysis: This story serves as a cautionary tale about inequality in relationships and the dangerous permanence of spoken words and curses. Shiva's intervention demonstrates how divine mercy can transform a destructive punishment into the natural, beautiful rhythm of lunar time.

2.2.5.2 The Origin of Bilva: Mount Mandara deeply worshipped Goddess Parvati and longed for her divine presence. One day, after Shiva and Parvati finished a vigorous dance, Parvati wiped her brow. A drop of her sweat fell upon Mandara, instantly sprouting the first Bilva tree. Blessing Mandara to eternally bear this flora, Parvati revealed that its trifoliate leaves represent the three cosmic realms and are deeply pleasing to Shiva.

Analysis: This brief narrative intimately connects the physical exertion of the divine to the creation of nature. It effectively establishes the ritualistic origins and spiritual significance of offering Bilva leaves in Hindu worship.

2.2.6 The Legend of the Elephant God

2.2.6.1 The God of Knowledge: Realizing Nandi's loyalty lay solely with Shiva, Parvati sculpted a boy, breathed life into him, and named him Ganesha to guard her bath. When

an oblivious Shiva arrived, Ganesha fiercely blocked his path, leading an enraged Shiva to sever the boy's head. A remorseful Shiva ordered Nandi to fetch the head of a north-facing creature, returning with an elephant's head to resurrect the boy. Later, during a race to circle the globe, Ganesha walked around his parents, declaring them his entire universe, which led Shiva to crown him the God of Knowledge.

Analysis: The story explores the complexities of loyalty, familial boundaries, and tragic misunderstandings. Ganesha's method of winning the race redefines the concept of wisdom, elevating familial reverence and intellect above sheer physical speed.

2.2.6.2 The Mighty Mouse: Krauncha, a celestial musician in Indra's court, accidentally stepped on Sage Vamadev and was cursed to become a giant, grain-destroying rat. Ganesha battled the beast and captured him with his Pasha (noose), taming the rat to magically alter its size and become his vehicle.

Analysis: This represents the divine subjugation of erratic, destructive earthly energies into a controlled, purposeful force that serves higher spiritual goals.

2.2.6.3 Durva: When the fire-demon Anasura terrorized the realms, Ganesha expanded his body and swallowed him whole, but suffered excruciating stomach pain from the internal flames. Every divine remedy failed until wise sages prescribed twenty-one blades of Himalayan durva grass, which finally extinguished the demon and the pain.

Analysis: A humbling narrative demonstrating that occasionally, simple, earthly solutions are far more effective than the grandest divine interventions.

2.2.7 The Slaying of the Asuras

2.2.7.1 The Tale of Three Cities: Tarakasura's three sons secured an invincible boon of three celestial fortresses that aligned only once a millennium. When they terrorized the cosmos, Shiva intervened using a solar-powered golden chariot and two mighty bows, obliterating the aligned cities with one strike. The bow Pinaka was passed down and renamed the Shivdhanush, which Ram famously lifted to marry Sita.

Analysis: The tale symbolizes the absolute eradication of synchronized evil. It also provides a fascinating narrative bridge between Shaivite mythology and the epic of the Ramayana.

2.2.7.2 The Elephant Demon: To avenge his father Mahishasura's demise, the demon Gajasura launched a terrifying war but surrendered after being pierced by Shiva. Gazing upon the divine forms of Shiva and Parvati, the dying demon repented and begged Shiva to wear his elephant hide so he could remain with the divine eternally. Shiva compassionately obliged.

Analysis: This story illustrates the theme of ultimate redemption at the moment of death. It highlights Shiva's boundlessly compassionate nature, showing his willingness to honor the devotion of even a sworn enemy.

2.2.7.3 A Lesson to the Tiger: Demons Dundubhi and Souhardya shape-shifted into tigers to slaughter unsuspecting worshippers at the Kashi Vishwanath temple on Maha Shivaratri. Instantly, Shiva manifested from the glowing Jyotirlinga, vanquished the beasts, and draped the tiger skin around himself as an eternal symbol of his triumph.

Analysis: The myth reinforces Shiva's role as the fierce, ultimate protector of his vulnerable devotees and serves as the mythological origin for his iconic tiger-skin attire.

2.2.7.4 The Half Man, The Half Woman: The devotee Bhringi was fiercely loyal to Lord Shiva but stubbornly refused to acknowledge Goddess Parvati. To bypass her during circumambulation, Bhringi transformed into a tiny honeybee to orbit Shiva alone. When Parvati and Shiva merged their bodies into a single form, the obsessed Bhringi bored a hole through their shared belly button to circle only Shiva's side. Furious that he rejected the mother, Parvati cursed him to lose his flesh and blood, leaving him a withered shell. Realizing his grave error, a humbled Bhringi begged for forgiveness and was mercifully restored, later serving eternally alongside Nandi.

Analysis: This provides a profound commentary on the inseparable duality of the masculine and feminine forces within the universe. It serves as a stern warning against

sectarian exclusivity, showing that worshipping one aspect of the divine while aggressively rejecting the other leads to spiritual and physical ruin.

2.2.8 Folk Tales

2.2.8.1 The Gift of Life: Given a divine choice, Mrikandu and Marudmati chose a virtuous son destined to die at sixteen over a wicked son with a long life. On his sixteenth birthday, Markandeya clung to a Shivalinga, and when Yama's death-noose accidentally struck the idol, a furious Shiva intervened, granting the boy eternal life.

Analysis: Suggests that exceptional virtue, unwavering devotion, and parental sacrifice can ultimately conquer even preordained destiny and death.

2.2.8.2 The Innocent Hunter: Kannappa, an unlettered orphan, innocently offered hunted rabbit meat to Shiva. Later, mistaking ritual marks on a Shivalinga for bleeding wounds, he prepared to gouge out his own eye to heal the deity. Touched by his raw, unblemished devotion, Shiva appeared and blessed him.

Analysis: Demonstrates that the Divine measures devotion not by adherence to formal rituals or learnedness, but by the raw sincerity and selflessness of the heart.

2.2.8.3 The Girl That God Made: Young Kodagusu stubbornly refused to leave the temple until Shiva physically drank her milk offering. Moved by her innocence, Shiva obliged, but when her skeptical father spied on her and cruelly accused her of lying, Shiva absorbed the heartbroken girl into the linga to forever protect her faith.

Analysis: A touching exploration of innocent, childlike faith triumphing over the cynical, logical skepticism of the adult world.

2.2.8.4 The Story of Adi Shankara: Shankara, a child prodigy, gained his mother's permission to become a monk to save his life when a crocodile caught his leg. He grew into a legendary philosopher who established four major mathas, famously defeated scholar Mandana Misra in a rigorous debate, and mysteriously vanished at age thirty-two.

Analysis: Traces the brief but monumentally influential life of a mortal philosopher, illustrating the power of intellect and spiritual dedication in shaping religious history.

2.2.8.5 The King of Kerala: A noble, disguised king discovered Rajalakshmi, the goddess of wealth, weeping outside a temple because she was destined to abandon his realm by dawn. Desperate to protect his subjects, the king asked her to hold his clothes while he bathed and extracted a vow that she would wait for his return. He then deliberately drowned himself, permanently binding the goddess to her promise to stay in Kerala.

Analysis: Depicts the ultimate model of servant-leadership, showcasing a ruler whose profound love for his people drove him to sacrifice his own life to secure their eternal economic salvation.

2.3 SAMBHAVAMI YUGE YUGE

2.3.1 The Bones of Dadhichi: Sage Dadhichi was a devoted and kind worshipper of Lord Vishnu who protected the gods' weapons whenever they were defeated in battle. When there was no war for many years, he dissolved the weapons using a sacred chant and drank the liquid, keeping their power within himself. Later, the demon Vritrasura, blessed that no wooden or metal weapon could kill him, stole all the world's water. As people suffered, Indra sought Dadhichi's help. The sage willingly sacrificed his life so his bones could be used to create the Vajrayudha. With it, Indra defeated Vritrasura and restored water to Earth.

Analysis: The story of Dadhichi teaches that true greatness lies in selfless sacrifice for the welfare of others

2.3.2 The Churning of the Ocean : The story begins when Sage Durvasa cursed Indra for disrespecting a sacred garland, causing the gods to lose their strength. The demons, led by Bali, defeated them. Seeking help, the gods approached Vishnu, who advised them to churn the ocean of milk with the asuras to obtain the nectar of immortality. Using Mount

Mandara and the serpent Vasuki, they began churning, while Vishnu supported the mountain as a turtle. Many treasures emerged, including Lakshmi, the moon, Kamadhenu, and deadly poison, which Shiva drank, becoming Neelkanth. Finally, Vishnu, as Mohini, tricked the asuras and gave the nectar to gods.

Analysis: The story shows that pride and disrespect can lead to downfall while humility and cooperation can bring success.

2.3.3 The Ten Avatars: Mother Earth, also called Bhudevi, went to Vaikuntha crying over the growing evil in the world. She told Vishnu that greed, cruelty, and injustice were becoming too heavy for her to bear. Vishnu gently assured her that whenever evil rises beyond control, he would descend to Earth in different forms called avatars to restore balance. These ten forms would be called dashavatars. He explained his ten incarnations: Matsya to save life from a flood, Kurma to support the churning ocean, Varaha to rescue Earth, Narasimha to protect devotion, Vamana to humble Bali, Parashurama to punish tyrants, Rama to defeat Ravana, Krishna to guide and destroy wicked kings, Buddha to teach peace, and Kalki to end evil.

Analysis: The story “The Ten Avatars” shows how Lord Vishnu takes different forms in different ages to restore balance and protect righteousness whenever evil increases.

2.3.4 The Big Fish: The story of the Big Fish tells about Manu, believed to be the first human created by Lord Brahma. One day, while offering water to the Sun God, Manu noticed a tiny fish in his palms. Feeling compassion, he placed it in his water pot to protect it. Surprisingly, the fish kept growing larger each day. Manu moved it from a pot to a pond, then to a lake, a river, and finally the sea, but it continued to grow. Realizing it was no ordinary fish, Manu asked its identity. The fish revealed itself as Lord Vishnu and warned him about a coming flood that would destroy the world. Vishnu instructed Manu to gather seeds, animals, people, and sacred texts in a large boat. When the flood arrived, Vishnu guided the boat safely. He also defeated the demon Hayagriva and recovered the stolen Vedas, preserving knowledge for humanity.

Analysis: The story teaches obedience, faith, and divine protection, showing how trust in God preserves life and knowledge during destruction.

2.3.5 The Large Dwarf: The story of the large dwarf is about king Bali, grandson of Prahlada and was also referred to as Mahabali because of his greatness. He was a kind ruler, but after time he became very proud of his success and strength. Indra was scared if Bali would take over heaven. To teach him a lesson, Lord Vishnu took a form of a dwarf named Vamana and went to visit Bali during a holy ceremony where he was giving gifts. Vamana asked three steps of land measured by his feet. Bali laughed at his request and accepted even though he was warned by his teacher. Suddenly Vamana became a giant. With only one step, he covered the earth and in the second step he covered the sky. There was no space left was in his third step.

After realizing Vamana was Vishnu itself, Bali gave willingly his head. Vishnu placed his feet on Bali's head and sent him to Pataal. In the lower world of mythology. Vishnu was filled admiration by looking at Bali's honesty. Vishnu gave him permission to visit his kingdom once a year celebrated as Onam.

Analysis: The story teaches humility and surrender, showing that pride fades but devotion and honesty earn divine grace.

2.3.6 Three Mortal Lifetimes: Jaya and Vijaya were the two devoted gatekeepers of the lord Vishnus heavenly home Vaikuntha. They were very proud of thier positions because they could see Vishnu every day. One day, the four Sanath Kumars, wise and pure sages who looked like small children, came to see Vishnu. Jaya and Vijaya mistakingly thought they were ordinary boys. They stopped them from entering. The Kumars felt disrespected by thier arrogance and cursed them to be born as mortals on earth. Vishnu appeared and calmly explained that devotees should never be stopped. The Kumars offered two choices seven lives as devotees or three as enemies. The guards chose three.

Analysis: The story teaches humility, showing how pride leads to downfall while devotion ultimately restores divine closeness.

2.3.7 Hiranyaksha and Hiranyakashipu: Jaya and Vijaya were born as the asura brothers Hiranyaksha and Hiranyakashipu. Hiranyaksha troubled the world and kidnapped mother earth. Then the Lord Vishnu took the form of an avatar Varaha, the wild boar, and killed him to save her. Hiranyakashipu then prayed to Lord Brahma and received a boon that made him almost to kill. He hated Vishnu and ordered everyone not to praise him. However the own son Prahlada, became a great worshipper of Vishnu. Hiranyakashipu tried many times to kill Prahlada, but Vishnu protected him to many times. Finally Vishnu appeared as Narasimha and killed Hiranyakashipu, saving Prahlada and restoring peace.

Analysis: The story shows that faith and devotion triumph over ego, cruelty, and false power.

2.3.8 Ravana and Kumbhakarna: All of us are aware of the story of the great epic Ramayana. In which Ravana the king of Lanka kidnapped Sita, Rama's wife. This led to great war between Rama and Ravana. Ravana's brother Kumbhakarna, was a powerful agent who slept for six months every year. Though he advised Ravana not to fight, he later joined the battle, only to be killed by Rama and Rama finally defeated Ravana. This is how the second mortal lives of Jaya and Vijaya, as Ravana and Kumbhakarna, finally ended.

Analysis: The story shows how arrogance leads to destruction, while righteousness and dharma ultimately prevail.

2.3.9 Shishupala and Dantavarkha: Damaghosh, the King of Chedi, and his wife, Srutadevi were extremely sad when their child was born. The newborn prince, who was named Shishupala was born with four arms and three eyes, which his parents worried about. They met a sage who says that he will become normal when he will be held by a person who would later kill him. When the baby Shishupala sat in Krishna's lap, his extra limbs disappeared. His mother begged Krishna to forgive his sons mistakes, and Krishna promised to forgive a hundred. As he grew up, Shishupala became arrogant and started hating Krishna. During a Royal ceremony, he insulted Krishna many times. After crossing a hundred mistakes, Krishna killed him with his Sudharshan Chakra. Dantarakra

was also killed by Krishna..

Analysis: Story shows Karma shapes destiny; humility and devotion lead soul toward growth, wisdom, and eventual liberation through repeated lifetimes.

2.3.10 A Friend in Need Ashes to Ashes: Once an asura who was a great devotee of Brahma performed a very simple and a deep prayer with self-discipline to please the God. Lord Brahma appeared and the asura asked for a dangerous boon, anyone whose head he touched would turn to ashes. Brahma accepted the wish and the asura became known as Bhasmasura. Soon Bhasmasura decided to test his power on Brahma himself. Understanding clearly the danger, Brahma ran away and asked Vishnu for life. Vishnu then decided to solve the problems cleverly. He took the form of the beautiful woman called Mohini. When Bhasmasura saw her, he was strongly attracted to her and asked to marry her. Mohini agreed on one condition, he must show that he could dance well. She began teaching him dance steps. As Bhasmasura copied her movements, Mohini cleverly gave directions to him to place his head on his own head. Without thinking he obeyed. The moment he touched his head, he turned into ashes. Mohini then showed the truth that he was Vishnu, thus Vishnu saved Brahma and brought back peace through intelligence instead of force

Analysis: The story teaches that intelligence and wisdom overcome pride and the reckless misuse of power.

2.3.11 The Elephant and the Crocodile: There once lived a king named Indradyumna, who was a devotee of Vishnu. One day the great sage Agastya came to visit Indradyumna on a hot summer day. At the palace the king did not bother to attend to Agastya or offer him something to drink. He showed no respect to the sage. The sage got very upset. Being angry the sage cursed him to be born as an Elephant. In another place a heavenly musician Gandharva insulted sage Devala and was cursed to become a crocodile. In their next lives Indradyumna became Gajendra, the king of Elephants and the Gandharva became a Crocodile.

One day while having bath in a lake, Gajendra was caught by a Crocodile. Despite his strength he could not free from the Crocodile. After struggling for many days, he recalls

his past life and prays truly and honestly to Vishnu for help. Vishnu appeared and killed the Crocodile with his Sudharshan Chakra. Both were freed from their curses and returned to their original forms.

Analysis: Story teaches true friendship is proven through loyalty, courage, and support during difficult times, not during comfort or happiness.

2.3.12 The Man from the Egg: Sage Kashyapa offered boons to his wives, Kadru and Vinata. Kadru wished for a thousand sons, while Vinata desired two powerful sons. Kadru's eggs hatched first, giving birth to many serpents. Vinata's eggs took longer, and in impatience she broke one early. The child inside, Aruna, was born incomplete and left to serve the Sun God, blaming his mother's haste. Later, Kadru tricked Vinata into losing a bet about a celestial horse's tail, making her a slave. Eventually, Vinata's second egg hatched, and Garuda was born strong and determined. He vowed to obtain nectar from heaven to free his mother.

Analysis: Story highlights destiny, courage, and divine purpose, showing how extraordinary birth leads to strength, responsibility, and fulfilling greater cosmic duty.

2.3.13 The Forked Tongues: Garuda, the very powerful son of Vinata, wanted his mother to be free from being Kadru's slave. To do this he had to get the divine drink nectar of immortality, which was in Indra's ownership. Indra didn't want to give it, so Vinata's son Garuda fought him bravely. Even Indra's powerful weapon, Vajrayudha, could not harm Garuda. Indra then took help from Vishnu. Garuda also fought with Vishnu, but no one defeated each other. Vishnu respected Garuda's devotion and made him his vehicle called as Garuda vahana, and promised Garuda that he will carry his image on the flag.

The Garuda Dhawaja. Vishnu allowed Garuda to take the nectar to free his mother from slavery but secretly planned to recover from it. Indra later fooled Kadru into leaving the pot without anyone watching it or taking care of it. Some snakes licked the spilled nectar from sharp hay, which spilt their tongues. This explains why snakes today have forked tongues.

Analysis: Story shows devotion and cleverness freeing Garuda's mother, while greed and deception explain snakes' forked tongues and consequences of desire.

2.3.14 The Honest Cheater: One day, Indra went to visit shiva on mount Kailash. He found someone who was not known to him. Then he comes to know that is he shiva himself. Shiva was in deep prayer and Jndra was disturbing shiva, and shiva was nearly killed, but shiva changed the direction of the arrow and threw it into the ocean, then a boy was created named Jalandhara. Blessed that shiva won against him, Jalandhara grew into a very powerful demon king and married Brinda, a worshipper of Vishnu. After knowing that Vishnu had cheated the demons during the churning of the ocean, Jalandhara announced war on the gods. Protected by Brindas prayers, he became very powerful. To stop him, Vishnu tricked Brinda into stopping her prayers, giving permission to shiva to kill Jalandhara. Brinda got angry and cursed Vishnu to become a stone, leading to the worship of Shaligrama and Tulsi.

Analysis: Story shows deception for greater good, highlighting devotion, pride, and consequences of divine justice.

2.3.15 Choice of Death: Madhu and Kaitabha were two demon brothers who asked goddess Parvati for immortality. When she said no, they in a smart way asked to die only at a time of their selection. After getting power, they became very unkind and proud in a bad way, even making Brahma feel ashamed. Brahma tried to get Vishnus help. Vishnu fought the demons, but since they could choose their death, he wanted Parvati's help. She influenced their thinking ability, and during a break in battle, they gave Vishnu a boon. Vishnu in a smart way wished for their death by his own hand. Bound by honor, they said yes. Before dying they requested temples in their name, which Vishnu granted.

Analysis: Story shows arrogance defeated through wisdom, teaching consequences of pride and destiny.

2.3.16 To Marry a Monkey or a Bear: A long time ago, there lived a king named Ambarish. He had a beautiful daughter name Shrimati. She was a charming princess. The king ambarish organised a Swayamvara for his daughter sages Narada and Parvata both fell in love with her and tried to win against other to marry her. Jealous and feeling

insecure, each of them asked Vishnu to make the other appear ugly. One like a monkey and the other like a bear. Vishnu granted both wishes. At the Swayamvara, Shrimati saw them with animal faces, but also saw Vishnu in his divine form and chose him instead. The sages realized they had been cleverly defeated. Vishnu made clear that Shrimati was Lakshmi's avatar and meant to marry him. Feeling ashamed of their selfishness the sages learned an important lesson.

Analysis: Story reveals jealousy and deception backfire, teaching humility and divine destiny.

2.3.17 The Web of illusion: Sage Narada often gave guidance to people to separate from the everyday life and material things and devote themselves fully to Vishnu. His father Brahma warned him that he did not understand the problems of common people. Ignoring this, Narada continued proudly. Vishnu then made an illusion to reach him a lesson. Narada went through a full mortal life marriage, children, love and fear and painful loss during the storm. Being sad and afraid he prayed to Vishnu. Suddenly the illusion ended, and Narada came to know that it was all not real. Vishnu made clear that attachment is powerful and difficult to overcome. Humbled, Narada accepted his father's wisdom.

Analysis: Story teaches power of attachment, illusion, and humility through divine lesson.

2.3.18 The Debt for a Wedding: Sage Bhrigu was chosen to decide which god should receive the fruits of a sacred yagna. He visited Brahma and Shiva but was not satisfied with them. When he reached Vishnu, he angrily kicked him. Vishnu calmly forgave Bhrigu and removed the extra eye on his foot, which had caused his pride. Realizing Vishnu's greatness, Bhrigu declared him supreme. However, Lakshmi felt insulted because Vishnu had been hurt and left Vaikuntha. Vishnu followed her to earth and meditated inside an anthill. A divine cow secretly fed him milk, but a misunderstanding led to a king being cursed and later reborn as Akasha Raja. The king found a baby girl, Padmavati, in a lotus. Vishnu, reborn as Srinivasa, fell in love with her and married her with Kubera's help. Later, he became Lord Venkateshwara on Venkatadri Hill, promising to protect humanity during Kali Yuga.

Analysis: Story explores devotion, destiny, sacrifice, and divine love shaping earthly responsibilities and faith.

2.3.19 The Asura and the Super God: Guha was a powerful asura who deeply worshipped Brahma and wished to become immortal. When Brahma refused to grant immortality, Guha cleverly asked for a boon that no god or human could kill him. After receiving this blessing, he became arrogant and cruel. He troubled sages, scholars, and ordinary people, spreading fear everywhere. The helpless people prayed to Shiva and Vishnu for protection. Since Brahma's boon made Guha impossible to defeat by a single god, Vishnu suggested combining his power with Shiva's strength. Together they formed a divine being called Harihara, who possessed qualities of both gods. When Harihara confronted Guha, the frightened asura tried to escape but was finally caught. Accepting his fate, Guha asked to remain under the god's feet. Harihara destroyed him, restoring peace. Later, a temple dedicated to this combined form was built, and Harihara continues to be worshipped today.

Analysis: Story shows unity of divine powers defeating evil and restoring cosmic balance.

The Man from the Egg shows that even gods are not free from the consequences of their actions. Through different stories, the book teaches that pride, greed, and ego always lead to destruction, while devotion, patience, and sacrifice bring peace and balance. By presenting Brahma, Vishnu, and Shiva in relatable ways, the author explains how the universe stays in harmony. Each story connects mythology with real human emotions and everyday life. Sudha Murty makes complex myths simple and meaningful for modern readers. In the end, the book reminds us that dharma and truth always win, and it encourages us to live with humility, responsibility, and faith in goodness.

CHAPTER 3: SUMMARY OF THE SAGE WITH TWO HORNS

Sudha Murty's second book *The Sage with Two Horns* is consist of thirty three short stories from Indian mythology. This book is consists of 5 section. 1st section *Guruve Namaha* is consist of 8 stories dealing with moral values and spiritual teachings given by Guru. The 2nd section *The Kings Who Become Saints* consist of 4 stories dealing with kings who give up their power and worldly pleasure to become saints, teaching lessons about youth, illusion, destiny, and the passing of time. The 3rd section *Raja Prithvi Pati* consist of 5 stories dealing with the wisdom, kindness, justice, and moral values of Raja Prithvi Pati. The section 4th, *A Bag of Surprises* consist of 8 stories dealing with surprising events from mythology that teach important lesson about life, destiny, wisdom, and different ways of thinking. The 5th section *Tales From The Vault* consist of 8 stories dealing with mysterious and unusual events from mythology that teach moral and spiritual lessons about life, faith, destiny, and human nature. The stories are as follows:

3.1 GURUVE NAMAH

3.1.1 The Mystery of Life and Death: Long ago, a boy named Nachiketa questioned his father for donating weak, old cows during a sacred ritual. Angered, his father rashly said he would give him to Yama, the god of death. Taking the words seriously, Nachiketa went to Yama's abode and waited three days without food. Impressed by his patience, Yama offered three wishes. Nachiketa first asked for peace with his father, then forgiveness for him. For the third, he asked the meaning of life and death. Moved by his courage and sincerity, Yama taught him spiritual truth, revealing that the soul lives beyond birth and death.

Analysis: This story teaches that real happiness comes from choosing what is right instead of running after money and pleasures. It also shows that being brave and eager to learn the truth leads to true understanding.

3.1.2 A Rainy Day: Sage Dhaumya lived in a gurukul with his students. One day, he sent his student Aruni to collect firewood. On the way back, heavy rain started. Aruni saw that the boundary of the rice field was breaking. If water entered, the crops would be destroyed. Aruni tried to fix it with mud and sticks, but the rain washed everything away. Finally, he lay down across the broken part to stop the water. He stayed there in the cold rain. When he did not return, the sage went looking for him. He found Aruni lying in the mud. The sage was proud of his dedication and brought him back safely. He praised him and gave him a new name, Uddalaka.

Analysis: This story shows that true dedication means putting others' needs before personal comfort. It teaches that sincerity, responsibility, and selfless service are the qualities of an ideal student.

3.1.3 The Boy with Eight Deformities Sujata, daughter of sage Uddalaka, married the scholar Kahoda. During her pregnancy, she listened to her husband's lessons so the child could learn in the womb. When Kahoda misrecited the Vedas, the unborn child corrected him. Angered, Kahoda cursed the baby to be born crooked in eight places. The child, named Ashtavakra, grew up physically deformed but highly intelligent. Later, Kahoda lost a debate in King Janaka's court against the scholar Vadin and was sentenced to remain underwater. At twelve, Ashtavakra learned the truth and went to Janaka's court. Despite mockery about his appearance, he impressed everyone with his sharp wisdom and defeated Vadin. He asked for the release of all captive sages, including his father. The debate was later revealed to serve a divine purpose. Afterward, Ashtavakra bathed in a sacred river and became straight. He later emerged as a respected philosopher teaching self-realisation and inner truth.

Analysis: This story shows that true knowledge and greatness come from inner wisdom, not physical appearance. It also teaches the value of forgiveness, courage, and confidence in standing for truth.

3.1.4 The Order of a Guru: Sage Dhaumya was a revered teacher with many students in his gurukul, including the obedient Upamanyu. To test his dedication, Dhaumya asked about his daily food and ordered him to surrender all he received. Upamanyu complied. When he secretly begged for alms to survive, the guru stopped that too. Then Upamanyu drank milk from the cows he grazed, but Dhaumya forbade this as well. Left without nourishment, Upamanyu endured extreme hunger. One day, in desperation, he ate poisonous leaves and lost his eyesight, falling into a dry well. When he failed to return, Dhaumya searched and found him helpless. The sage prayed to the Ashwini Kumars, who offered medicine to cure him. Yet Upamanyu refused to accept it without his guru's approval. Touched by such loyalty, Dhaumya blessed him with wisdom and permitted the cure. His sight returned, and Upamanyu later became a respected sage known for unwavering obedience.

Analysis: This story shows that true devotion means obeying and trusting one's teacher even during hardships. It teaches that patience, faith, and sincere dedication lead to wisdom, blessings, and ultimate success in life.

3.1.5 The Animals That Spoke: Sage Gautama guided many students in his ashram, including Satyakama, the honest son of Jabala. Known for his truthfulness, Satyakama earned his teacher's trust. One day, Gautama sent him into the forest with four hundred weak cows, asking him to return only when they became a thousand. Satyakama patiently cared for the herd, living simply and protecting them with dedication. Over time, the cows grew strong and multiplied. When they reached a thousand, a bull miraculously spoke, advising him to return and teaching him a part of divine truth. On his journey back, the fire god Agni, a swan, and a diver bird each shared deeper spiritual knowledge. These revelations helped him understand the nature of God and reality. When Satyakama returned, Gautama recognized his spiritual growth and blessed him. He later became a respected sage, remembered for sincerity, devotion, and unwavering commitment to truth.

Analysis: This story teaches that true knowledge can come from anywhere when the heart is pure and open to learning. Kindness, honesty, and dedication make a person worthy of receiving higher wisdom.

3.1.6 The Snake That Stole Earrings: Sage Veda's devoted student Uttanka completed his education and asked what he could offer as guru dakshina. At the guru's request, Uttanka approached his wife, who asked for the queen of King Pushya's rare earrings to wear at a festival. Uttanka agreed and set out. On the way, he accepted a strange drink from a mysterious giant. After purifying himself through prayer, he received the earrings, though the queen warned him that the serpent king Takshaka desired them. While returning, Takshaka stole the earrings and escaped into an anthill. Determined, Uttanka pursued him and received help from Indra, who enabled him to reach the serpent world. By divine power, Uttanka forced Takshaka to return the jewels. He delivered them in time and later learned that the strange events were divine tests. Blessed for his faith, Uttanka became known for bringing rain to dry lands.

Analysis: This story teaches that when a person is sincere, determined, and faithful to their duty, they can overcome any difficulty. It also shows that hard work and devotion always bring support and blessings at the right time.

3.1.7 The Story of Agastya: Agastya, one of the revered Saptarishis, was known for his wisdom and spiritual power. A king of Vidarbha once prayed for a child, and through Agastya's blessing, a daughter named Lopamudra was born. When she came of age, Agastya, encouraged by his ancestors to marry, asked for her hand. Though there was a great age difference, Lopamudra agreed and left her royal life to live in the forest. With his powers, Agastya ensured her comfort, and she became wise and devoted. Later, they travelled south, where Agastya humbled the rising Vindhya mountains by asking them to remain bowed. Lopamudra later transformed into the river Kaveri to serve humanity. Agastya also defeated the demon brothers Vatapi and Ilvala and even drank the ocean to help the gods destroy hidden demons. He remains honoured as a sage who combined wisdom, courage, and compassion.

Analysis: This story teaches that true greatness comes from using knowledge and strength to help others. It also shows that a life of service, courage, and sacrifice makes a person truly respected and remembered.

3.1.8 A Tale of Three Fathers: King Harishchandra longed for a son and prayed to Varuna, who granted his wish on the condition that the child would be returned when asked. After Rohit was born, the king became attached and repeatedly delayed fulfilling his promise. When Varuna insisted, Rohit fled to the forest, and the king was cursed with a painful disease. To save himself, Harishchandra sought to adopt another boy for sacrifice. A poor man, Ajigrata, agreed to give his son Shunashepa in exchange for wealth. During the ritual, Shunashepa questioned the morality of his father, the king, and even Varuna. Impressed by his courage, Sage Vishvamitra taught him sacred hymns. Varuna then revealed the events were a test, cured the king, and freed the boy. Vishvamitra adopted Shunashepa, renaming him Devarata. He later became a respected scholar remembered for wisdom and integrity.

Analysis: This story teaches that greed, selfishness, and breaking promises can lead to suffering and shame. It also shows that wisdom, courage, and speaking the truth make a person truly great and respected.

3.2 THE KINGS WHO BECAME SAINTS

3.2.1 The Hands of Destiny: A Chera king had two sons—Senguttuvan, the elder, and his gifted younger brother. When an astrologer predicted that the younger prince would earn lasting fame, he chose to step aside, believing destiny is shaped by choice. He became the poet Ilango Adigal and wrote *Silappadikaram*. The epic tells of Kannagi, whose husband Kovalan was wrongly executed for stealing the queen's anklet. Proving his innocence by revealing her anklet held rubies, not pearls, Kannagi's grief turned to fierce anger, and Madurai burned. Her story lives on as a reminder that justice must prevail and courage can challenge even kings.

Analysis: This story teaches that destiny is shaped by choices, courage, and actions rather than predictions alone. It also shows that injustice and careless decisions by those in power can lead to great suffering and destruction.

3.2.2 The Wheel of Time: When King Rishabhadeva renounced his throne, he divided his kingdom among his sons. Soon, a divine wheel appeared before Bharata, signalling imperial destiny. As he conquered lands, the wheel stopped because his brothers had not accepted him. Most surrendered peacefully, but Bahubali challenged Bharata to a personal duel to avoid bloodshed. Bahubali won, yet victory felt empty. Realising that power fades and life is temporary, he chose a higher path. Leaving the throne behind, he meditated in deep silence, seeking liberation. In time, Bahubali became a symbol of detachment and spiritual strength, remembered for choosing peace over power.

Analysis: This story teaches that power, victory, and success have no real meaning if they do not bring inner peace. It shows that true greatness lies in self-control, forgiveness, and choosing spiritual growth over worldly ambition.

3.3 RAJA PRITHVI PATI

3.3.1 A Beggar, a Dog and a Bird: In Vaikuntha, Lord Vishnu praised King Rantideva as his most compassionate devotee. Doubting this, some gods decided to test him by causing a severe drought in his kingdom. As his people suffered, Rantideva generously distributed all the royal food and chose to fast himself. Weak and starving, he finally agreed to eat a small portion of rice. Just then, a beggar arrived, and the king gave him the food. When more rice was brought, a hungry dog consumed it. Only water remained, but a thirsty bird appeared, and Rantideva offered the water without hesitation. Though left with nothing, he felt content, believing service to living beings was service to God. Vishnu and the other gods then revealed the test and ended the drought. Offered a boon, Rantideva asked only for the strength to relieve others' suffering, proving his true compassion.

Analysis: This story teaches that true compassion means helping others even when one is suffering. It shows that real devotion is not about praying for personal gain, but about caring for all living beings selflessly.

3.3.2 How the Earth Turned into Cow: King Vena ruled cruelly, causing misery throughout his kingdom. When the people could no longer endure his tyranny, they overthrew him. His son Prithu then became king. Though wise and just, Prithu faced a terrible problem—crops failed, and the Earth seemed unwilling to provide food. Seeking answers, he approached Mother Earth. Afraid he might be like his father, she transformed into a cow and fled. Prithu first aimed his bow at her but soon realized violence would only deepen suffering. Instead, he humbly promised to protect and honor her, asking her to nourish his people. Touched by his sincerity, she agreed, and from then on was called Prithvi, symbolically his daughter. Under Prithu's guidance, agriculture and organized society flourished. He became known as the first righteous king, whose virtuous rule even redeemed his father and strengthened civilization.

Analysis: This story shows that force and anger cannot solve problems, but patience and understanding can bring positive change. It also teaches that a good ruler protects nature and works for the welfare of the people.

3.3.3 The Intelligent Python: King Ayu's infant son was kidnapped by a demon in disguise but was secretly saved and raised by sage Vasishtha. Named Nahusha, he grew into a brave and powerful ruler. After defeating Indra, pride consumed him. Desiring Indra's wife, Shachi, he forced seven sages to carry his palanquin and insulted sage Agastya. Enraged, Agastya cursed him to become a python. Years later, as a serpent, Nahusha captured Bhima. Wise King Yudhishtira answered his deep questions about truth and knowledge, breaking the curse. Humbled at last, Nahusha realized that arrogance destroys, but wisdom and humility restore honor.

Analysis: This story shows that pride and arrogance can destroy even the greatest and most powerful person. Nahusha becomes successful and defeats Indra, but his disrespect toward women and sages leads to his downfall.

3.3.4 A Pigeon's Weight: King Shibi of Kashi was known for his kindness and fairness. One day, a frightened pigeon sought refuge in his court, chased by a hungry eagle. The eagle demanded its prey, but Shibi refused to betray the bird's trust. To honor both justice and compassion, he offered his own flesh equal to the pigeon's weight. No matter how

much he cut from his thigh, the scale would not balance. Finally, Shibi stepped onto the scale himself, ready to give his life. The pigeon and eagle then revealed themselves as gods, blessing Shibi for his unwavering promise and selfless heart.

Analysis: This story shows that true greatness lies in selfless sacrifice and compassion. It teaches that keeping one's promise and following dharma is more important than one's own life.

3.3.5 The Sudarshan Chakra and the Sage: King Ambarisha, a devoted follower of Vishnu, observed the Ekadashi fast for a year for his people's welfare. On the final day, sage Durvasa visited but delayed returning from his bath as the sacred time to break the fast approached. Torn between duty and hospitality, Ambarisha sipped a little water on his guru's advice. Durvasa, angered, created a demon to attack him. The king prayed sincerely, and Vishnu's Sudarshan Chakra destroyed the demon and chased the sage. Realizing his mistake, Durvasa sought forgiveness. Peace was restored, and Ambarisha's devotion became forever linked with the Ekadashi fast.

Analysis: This story teaches that true devotion means having a clean heart and trusting God in difficult times

3.3.6 A Star is Born: Long ago, young Dhruva felt invisible in his own palace. His father favored his stepbrother, and one day his stepmother cruelly told him he did not deserve the king's love. Heartbroken, Dhruva turned to his mother, who gently advised him to seek comfort in prayer. Determined to prove his worth, the small boy went alone into the forest and meditated on Lord Vishnu with unshakable faith. Even the sage Narada could not change his resolve. Touched by such devotion, Vishnu blessed Dhruva to shine forever as the Pole Star, guiding others through darkness with steady light.

Analysis: The story highlights Dhruva's determination and unwavering faith, showing that devotion and perseverance lead to divine blessings. It teaches that true recognition comes from inner virtue, not worldly favoritism.

3.3.7 The Way You Look at It: One day, Karna, the half-brother of the Pandavas, was sitting alone in deep thought. His face showed pain and confusion. Seeing this, Krishna gently invited him for a ride on his chariot. Krishna drove the horses while Karna sat behind him. The cool wind blew, but Karna's heart was still heavy. After some time, Krishna asked him what troubled him. Karna spoke about his difficult life. He said he was abandoned at birth, insulted for not knowing his true identity, and denied respect even though he was a great warrior. He felt that life had been unfair to him. Krishna listened patiently and then replied calmly. He said that every person faces pain in life. He himself was born in prison and faced many dangers from childhood. The Pandavas also suffered injustice and exile. "Life is not always fair," Krishna said, "but that does not give us the right to choose the wrong path. True dharma is knowing what is right and following it, even when it is hard." He explained that a person should not blame fate for wrong actions. Instead, one must rise above hurt and act with honesty and courage. Our choices define who we are. Karna remained silent, thinking deeply about Krishna's words.

Analysis: The story emphasizes that life may be unfair, but true strength lies in following dharma and making righteous choices. It teaches that personal integrity matters more than circumstances or suffering.

3.3.8 A Simple Life: Once there was a learned sage named Kaushika. One day, he was meditating under a tree. A crane sitting on the branches accidentally dropped dirt on him. Angry at this, Kaushika looked at the bird with fury. By the power of his penance, the crane immediately turned into ashes. The sage felt proud of his spiritual strength. The next day, he went to a house to beg for food. The housewife was busy serving her family and was delayed in attending to him. Kaushika grew angry again and looked at her harshly. Calmly, she said, "I am not a crane to be burnt by your anger." The sage was shocked. He asked how she knew about the crane. The woman replied that she was not highly educated, but she performed her duties sincerely—caring for her husband, children, elders, and guests. Her devotion to duty gave her inner wisdom. She then advised him to meet her guru, Dharmavyadha. Curious, Kaushika went to find him. He was surprised to see that Dharmavyadha was a simple butcher. Yet the butcher welcomed him and said he already knew why he had come. He explained that true wisdom comes from doing one's

duty honestly and serving others with love, not from pride or anger. Kaushika realized his mistake. He understood that real greatness lies in humility and righteous action. He gave up his pride and chose to live a life of kindness.

Analysis: The story highlights that true wisdom and power come from humility, duty, and selfless service, not from pride or anger. It teaches that inner greatness is earned through righteous actions, not mere spiritual prowess.

3.3.9 The Invincible Princes: Hamsa and Dimbika were two powerful asura princes. They wished to become undefeatable, so they performed severe penance to please Shiva. Pleased with their devotion, Shiva granted them a boon. He blessed that they would not die by any weapon or by the hands of any person. Though Shiva knew such a boon could create trouble, he kept his word. After receiving the boon, the two princes became proud. Believing they were invincible, they started troubling people and spreading fear. Their strength attracted the attention of Jarasandha, the powerful king of Magadha. He invited them to become his generals, and they gladly accepted. Together, they increased his power and ruled harshly. At that time, Jarasandha's daughters, Asti and Prapti, were married to Kamsa, the cruel king of Mathura. Kamsa wanted to expand his empire and asked Jarasandha to send Hamsa and Dimbika to help him. But events took a different turn. Through clever strategy and fate, confusion arose between the two brothers. Each believed the other had died, and in grief and shock, they lost their lives—without any weapon being used. Thus, their own pride and misunderstanding destroyed them.

Analysis: The story shows that pride and arrogance can lead to one's downfall, no matter how powerful one becomes. It teaches that overconfidence and misunderstanding can be more destructive than any external threat.

3.3.10 The Girl who Wanted the Death Penalty: There once lived a king named Punyaneedhi, a great devotee of Vishnu in the southern land. In Vaikuntha, a gentle debate arose between Vishnu and Lakshmi. Lakshmi said that she had more devotees on earth because people prayed for wealth and prosperity. Vishnu smiled and replied that devotion is not about numbers, but about true faith and sincerity. To test this, Lakshmi went to earth disguised as a poor eight-year-old girl. She entered King Punyaneedhi's

kingdom and created a situation where she was accused of stealing from the temple. According to the strict law of the land, theft from the temple was punishable by death. When brought before the king, the young girl boldly asked for the death penalty, saying that justice must be equal for all. The king was troubled. He believed in justice, but he also felt compassion for the child. Instead of blindly giving punishment, he prayed to Vishnu for guidance and offered to accept the punishment himself if the girl was guilty under his rule. At that moment, Lakshmi revealed her true form. She praised the king's fairness and deep devotion. Vishnu's words were proven true—true devotion lies in purity of heart, not in numbers.

Analysis: The story highlights that true devotion is measured by sincerity and righteousness, not by popularity or wealth. It also shows that a just and compassionate heart reflects genuine faith.

3.3.11 The Indras who Became the Pandavas : Long ago, sages and gods were performing a great yagna in the holy forest of Naimisharanya. They requested Yama to manage the arrangements. Because of this duty, Yama became busy, and for some time, no one on earth died. Seeing this, Indra grew restless. He complained to his father, Brahma, saying that Yama had neglected his work. Brahma calmly replied that once the yagna ended, everything would return to normal. But Indra was not satisfied. He went to earth to question Yama himself. While wandering, he saw a golden lotus floating on a river. Curious to know its source, he followed it. On the way, he met a young maiden who was crying, but she gave no reply to his questions. Moving ahead, Indra saw a couple playing chess. They ignored him completely. Feeling insulted, Indra lifted his weapon in anger. At that moment, the man looked at him, and Indra became frozen. The couple then revealed themselves as Shiva and Parvati. They told Indra that his pride and impatience would be punished. He would be born on earth as a human, as one of the Pandavas, to learn humility through suffering.

Analysis: The story emphasizes that pride and impatience can lead to downfall, even for the powerful. It also teaches that humility and self-restraint are essential virtues.

3.3.12 The Lazy Philosopher: King Bharata renounced his throne to seek spiritual truth. In the forest, he rescued a helpless fawn and gradually grew deeply attached to it. At death, his thoughts lingered on the deer, and he was reborn as one, remembering his past mistake. After another birth as a quiet, detached man called Jada Bharata, he avoided worldly ties and focused only on the soul. Mistaken for lazy, he once carried a king's palanquin but walked slowly, lost in thought. When questioned, he calmly spoke about the soul's true identity. The humbled king recognized his wisdom and became his devoted learner.

Analysis: This story highlights the importance of detachment and spiritual focus. It shows that worldly duties and appearances are temporary, and true wisdom lies in understanding the soul and prioritizing inner knowledge over material concerns.

3.3.13 The Mystery of the Identical Nose Rings: Srinivasa Nayaka was wealthy but extremely miserly, while his wife Saraswati longed to help the poor. One day, a needy stranger asked for money. Unable to refuse, Saraswati secretly gave him her only personal ornament—her nose ring. The stranger later tried to mortgage it at Srinivasa's shop, making him suspicious. When confronted, Saraswati feared his anger, but miraculously the same nose ring reappeared in her prayer room. Realizing the visitor was Lord Vishnu in disguise, Srinivasa felt ashamed. The incident transformed him into Purandara Dasa, a humble devotee who renounced wealth for a life of faith and music.

Analysis: This story shows that true wealth lies in devotion, humility, and selfless service rather than material possessions. It also highlights how a small act of kindness can lead to great spiritual transformation.

3.4 TALES FROM THE VAULT

3.4.1 The Man with No Hands: A gifted sculptor dreamed of carving a grand statue of Bahubali. With royal support, he created a magnificent monument that won widespread praise. Fearing he might build something greater elsewhere, the jealous king cruelly ordered his right hand cut off. Undeterred, the sculptor used his left hand to craft an even taller statue in another kingdom—only to lose that hand too. Refusing to surrender, he

designed a final masterpiece using his skill and voice, guiding others to build it. Yet again betrayed, he lost his tongue. Though silenced, his greatest creation stood tall, proving true talent cannot be destroyed.

Analysis: The story shows that true talent and determination cannot be stopped, even when faced with unfair obstacles. It also reflects how jealousy and greed can destroy relationships and harm others.

3.4.2 The Case of the Unfinished Verse: Princess Vidyadhari wished to marry a man wiser than herself, but pride clouded her heart. A clever minister tricked her into marrying a simple shepherd by misinterpreting his foolish gestures as deep wisdom. When she discovered the truth, she angrily told him only Goddess Kali could grant him knowledge. Desperate to change, the young man prayed sincerely and was blessed with extraordinary learning, becoming the poet Kalidasa. Years later, while helping a dancer complete a king's unfinished verse, he was tragically killed out of fear and jealousy. Thus, brilliance born from humility ended in sorrow.

Analysis: The story shows that anyone, no matter how ordinary, can become great with learning, effort, and guidance. It also teaches that patience, help from others, and a little luck or divine support can change a person's life.

3.4.3 The Sage with Two Horns: Rishyasringa, raised in deep forest isolation by his strict father Vibhandaka, had never seen a woman. Innocent and pure-hearted, he knew nothing of the wider world. When a severe drought struck King Romapada's kingdom, it was believed that the young sage's presence could bring rain. Clever dancers lured him away with kindness and curiosity he had never experienced before. The moment he stepped into Anga, rain poured down, saving the people. He later married Princess Shanta and chose to stay. Though Vibhandaka arrived in anger, seeing his son's goodness soften suffering, he blessed the couple and returned peacefully.

Analysis: This story shows that pure innocence and devotion can bring great blessings and positive change to the world. It also teaches that guidance and trust can help someone achieve what seems impossible.

3.4.4 The Disappearing Steps: Long ago, a sacred throne believed to inspire perfect justice belonged to wise rulers like Yudhishtira and later Vikramaditya. After disappearing for centuries, it was unknowingly rediscovered beneath a small hillock where village boys found they could settle quarrels wisely while sitting on it. When the hill was excavated, a magnificent throne with golden dolls was revealed. As a curious king tried to climb it, each doll narrated stories of truly great rulers and questioned his worthiness. Realizing he lacked their virtue, he stepped back. Instantly, the throne vanished, reminding all that true justice demands humility.

Analysis: The story shows that true justice comes from wisdom and virtue, not just power or position. It also teaches that only a humble and righteous person can handle great responsibility.

3.4.5 The Baby with Three Heads: Sage Atri and his devoted wife Anasuya longed for a child blessed with divine grace. When pride stirred among the goddesses Lakshmi, Parvati, and Saraswati, they sent their gods asked for food. With pure motherly love, Anasuya transformed them into infants and nursed them. Humbled, the goddesses begged for their return. Pleased with her selflessness, the Trinity blessed Anasuya with a son embodying their combined energies—Dattatreya. The child, symbolically shown with three heads, later became a wandering teacher, spreading wisdom and devotion wherever he went.

Analysis: The story shows that true power comes from love, devotion, and humility rather than ego or boasting. It teaches that selfless service and duty can create miracles and earn divine blessings.

3.4.6 The Son of Vishnu and Shiva: When the demoness Mahishi believed she could only be defeated by a child born of Shiva and Vishnu, she thought herself invincible. To end her cruelty, Vishnu took the form of Mohini, and a divine child, Manikanta, was born. Found in the forest by childless King Rajasekhara, he was raised as a prince. Jealousy later pushed the queen to send him on a deadly quest for tigress's milk. Instead, Manikanta defeated Mahishi and returned riding a tiger. Revealing his divine nature, he forgave all and chose a spiritual path, later worshipped as Lord Ayyappa of Sabarimala.

Analysis: The story shows that true divinity and courage come from purpose and destiny, not just birth. Manikanta's life teaches that faith, duty, and righteousness can overcome even the most impossible challenges.

3.4.7 The Most Important God of All: Once, the planetary gods argued about who was most powerful. King Vikramaditya cleverly avoided choosing, but Shani felt insulted and warned him of Sade Sati, a long period of hardship. Soon, the king lost his kingdom, wealth, and even his limbs, living as a humble servant. Despite deep suffering, he never complained and kept his faith. When the difficult phase ended, Shani appeared, restored his body, and explained that trials teach humility and wisdom. Vikramaditya realized that true strength lies in patience and devotion, and he honored Shani as the god who reveals life's deepest lessons.

Analysis: This story shows that challenges and hardships teach patience, humility, and wisdom. Enduring difficulties with faith helps one understand the higher powers that guide life.

3.4.8 You or You or You: One day, all beings of the universe began arguing about who was truly the greatest. The River Ganga claimed she was supreme because she cleansed sins. But others said she flowed on Earth, so Earth must be greater. Earth pointed to Sesha Naga who carried her; Sesha pointed to Shiva; Shiva to Mount Kailash; Kailash to Ravana; Ravana to Rama; Rama to his devotees. Finally, the devotees said their strength came from chanting God's name. Everyone fell silent, realizing that divine faith—not power, pride, or position—is the greatest force, quietly guiding every heart in the world.

Analysis: The story shows that true power does not lie in strength or position, but in faith and devotion. It teaches that God's name and the sincerity of devotees are the most supreme forces in the world.

The Sage with Two Horns brings together inspiring mythological stories that highlight the power of innocence, devotion, humility, and righteousness. Through the story of Rishyasringa and many other characters, the book shows that purity of heart and sincere faith can bring prosperity, peace, and transformation. It teaches that pride and ego lead to downfall, while wisdom, compassion, and self-control lead to harmony.

Sudha Murty presents these ancient tales in a simple and engaging manner, making them meaningful for modern readers. By connecting mythology with human emotions and moral values, the book reminds us that true greatness lies not in power, but in character. In the end, it encourages us to follow dharma, stay humble, and trust that goodness and truth always prevail.

CHAPTER 4: SUMMARY OF THE DAUGHTER FROM A WISHING TREE

The Daughter from a Wishing Tree is the 3rd story book, it consists of 4 sections. The 1st section is *Saraswati Bhagawati* having only one story. The 2nd section consist of *Narayani Namostute* having 2 stories. Likewise the 3rd section is consist of 6 stories under the subheading *Shive Sarvaartha Saadhike* and the last section i.e *Yatra Naryastu Pujyante Ramante Tatra Devata* contain 15 stories. The book starts with stories of powerful goddesses. The stories are as follows:

4.1 SARASWATI BHAGAWATI

4.1.1 The Source of Knowledge: Goddess Saraswati, created by Brahma, assists him with her knowledge and wisdom. She possesses a book of knowledge that helps the gods win battles against the asuras. When the asuras steal the book, Saraswati uses her expertise to retrieve it, transforming into a river to drown them. Later, she agrees to leave a part of her power on earth as the river Saraswati, joining Ganga and Yamuna at Prayag. In a related tale, the Trinity (Brahma, Vishnu, and Shiva) combine their energies to create a goddess to slay the powerful asura Andhaka. This goddess is worshipped as Shakti, Vaishnavi, Kali, Chamundi, Durga, and Saraswati, among other names.

Analysis: This story highlights the Saraswati's importance as a goddess of knowledge and wisdom. Highlighted her transformation into a sacred river (Saraswati).

4.2 NARAYANI NAMOSTUTE

4.2.1 The Eight Forms: Lakshmi is the Hindu goddess of wealth, fortune, and prosperity. She is also revered in Buddhism and Jainism. According to mythology, Lakshmi emerged from the ocean's churning, known as Samudra Manthana. She was so beautiful that all beings, including devas, asuras, humans, and Gandharvas, gazed at her in awe. Her father, the king of the ocean, gave her the freedom to choose her husband, and she chose Vishnu. Lakshmi has eight distinct forms, known as Ashtalakshmis, each representing different aspects of her blessings. These forms include Adilakshmi, her original gentle form;

Dhanyalakshmi, the goddess of grains worshipped by farmers; Dhairyalakshmi, symbolizing courage and strength; Gajalakshmi, depicted with elephants pouring gold; Santaanalakshmi, associated with children and worshipped by childless couples; Vijayalakshmi, the goddess of victory and courage; Vidyalakshmi, representing knowledge and education; and Dhanalakshmi, the goddess of wealth with gold pouring from her hand. In India, people worship Lakshmi in these various forms, seeking her blessings according to their needs and desires. Her presence is believed to bring prosperity and good fortune, making her a beloved and important deity in Hindu tradition.

Analysis: In this story Highlights the eight forms of goddess Laxmi, and how People worship her to find balance and happiness.

4.2.2 The God with the Head of a Horse: Hayagriva, a powerful asura king, desperately sought immortality, but Shakti, the goddess, refused his request. Undeterred, Hayagriva cleverly conditioned his death, stating that only a being with his name and a horse's head could kill him, believing this condition made him virtually invincible. Ironically, Vishnu's head was accidentally severed when ants cut the string of his bow, leading to his beheading. Shakti then intervened, taking the head of a nearby horse and placing it on Vishnu's body, transforming him into Hayagriva. In this extraordinary form, Vishnu-Hayagriva confronted and defeated the original Hayagriva asura, thus restoring cosmic balance. Additionally, Hayagriva is considered one of Vishnu's Dashavataras forms, symbolizing knowledge and wisdom. He is often depicted with four hands, carrying a Sudarshana Chakra. Devotees offer him a unique dessert called Hayagriva, made with chana dal, showcasing his significance in Hindu worship and tradition. The story underscores themes of divine intervention, cleverness, and the cyclical nature of power and balance in the universe.

Analysis: in this story we can shows how divine justice works in a clever way, and Vishnu's Hayagriva form helps to restore balance.

4.3 SHIVE SARVAARTHA SAADHIKE

4.3.1 The Power of Faith: King Dhruvasanti of Kosala had two wives, Manorama and Leelavati, each with a son - Sudarshana and Shatrujit, respectively. The king was killed by a lion while hunting, leading to a succession crisis. Yudajit, Leelavati's father, wanted Shatrujit to be king, so he invaded Kosala. Manorama's father, Virasena, fought back but was killed. Manorama fled with Sudarshana to the River Ganga, where sage Bharadwaja sheltered them. Shatrujit became king. Yudajit later discovered Sudarshana's whereabouts and planned to kill him, but the kingdom's ministers advised against it due to Bharadwaja's protection. Sudarshana learned a mantra from Bharadwaja, chanting "Kleem Kleem", which signified Devi. His devotion led Devi to appear, blessing him with a divine bow and arrow. Princess Sasikala of Kashi fell in love with Sudarshana upon hearing of Devi's blessing. At Sasikala's swayamvara, Sudarshana was invited, but Yudajit opposed the match. Devi appeared on a tiger, killing Yudajit and Shatrujit. Sudarshana was crowned king of Kosala, dedicating himself to Devi and celebrating her annually.

Analysis: In this, the story highlights the power of faith and divine intervention in overcoming adversity.

4.3.2 The Goddess of Fruits and Vegetables: Goddess Parvati, as Durga, fought and killed the powerful demon Durgamasura who had stopped rains and caused suffering. After his defeat, Parvati created a beautiful garden with abundant vegetables, becoming known as Banashankari or the goddess of the garden. She is worshipped for fertility and prosperity. The story highlights Parvati's strength and her role in restoring balance to nature. Durgamasura's demise showcases the triumph of good over evil, emphasizing the importance of divine feminine power in Hindu mythology, bringing peace and abundance to the world.

Analysis: In this story we can see how goddess Pravati saved the world, Foughjt evil, nourished earth.

4.3.3 The Steps to Heaven: Kunti, the mother of the Pandavas, lived with her husband's brother Dhritarashtra and his family in Hastinapur after King Pandu's death. She felt unwelcome and worried about her children's future since they didn't have a father or kingdom. Sage Narada visited and advised Kunti and Gandhari to pray to Goddess Parvati for their children's welfare. Narada suggested performing the Gaja Gowri puja in the month of Bhadrapada. Kunti wanted her sons to be strong and respected, so she performed the puja with Arjuna's help. Indra granted her wish, allowing Arjuna to bring Airavata, his elephant, to earth for the puja. Parvati blessed Kunti, wishing her children to be remembered for their good deeds and dharma. The story highlights the Gaja Gowri puja, done in Karnataka for children's welfare, typically lasting sixteen days with daily offerings.

Analysis: Kunti's devotion and Parvati's blessing highlight maternal love and protection. The Gaja Gowri puja, a 16-day ritual, ensures children's well-being and virtue.

4.3.4 To War with a Woman: The story revolves around two asura brothers, Shumbha and Nishumbha, who were sons of the cruel asura Shambara. They performed severe penance in Pushkara and prayed to Lord Brahma, seeking a boon. Brahma granted them the wish that they couldn't be killed by any male being, whether human, bird, animal, or god. The brothers became powerful and their atrocities increased, assisted by warriors Chanda and Munda. One day, Chanda and Munda saw Goddess Parvati, reported her beauty to Shumbha, and he sent a marriage proposal. Parvati refused, saying she'd marry someone who defeats her in battle. Shumbha sent soldiers, but Parvati, armed and riding a tiger, killed them, including Chanda and Munda. Enraged, Shumbha and Nishumbha fought Parvati but were slayed by her, fulfilling Brahma's boon that they would die at a woman's hands.

Analysis: In this story Parvati's victory over Shumbha and Nishumbha highlights female empowerment and divine justice.

4.3.5 The Woman of the Battlefield: The tale begins with two asura brothers, Rambha and Karambha, who sought special powers through intense meditation. Rambha prayed to Agni, the fire god, while Karambha prayed to Varuna, the water god. Indra, fearing their growing strength, disguised himself as a crocodile and killed Karambha. Rambha escaped with Agni's help and later became the asura king, fathering a son named Mahishasura, meaning "buffalo-headed asura". Mahishasura learned of his uncle's death and sought revenge against Indra. He prayed to Brahma for immortality, but Brahma granted a boon that he would die only at a woman's hands. Confident in his strength, Mahishasura waged war against Indra and drove the gods out. The gods united and created Durga, a powerful goddess combining their strengths, as Parvati's avatar. She was gifted weapons and a tiger mount. Brahma asked Durga to defeat Mahishasura, and she battled fiercely on Chamundi Hill in Mysuru, Karnataka, ultimately killing him. This legend is described in the Devi Mahatmyam and is celebrated during Navratri, where Parvati is worshipped in forms like Vaishnavi, Kali, and Durga.

Analysis: In this story Durga's victory over Mahishasura symbolizes good triumphing over evil and showcases feminine power in Hindu mythology.

4.3.6 The Daughter from a Wishing Tree: In the story The Daughter from a Wishing Tree, Goddess Parvati feels lonely because her husband Shiva spends most of his time in deep meditation and her sons are busy with their own duties. She wishes for a daughter with whom she can share her feelings. Parvati goes to the magical Kalpavriksha the wishing or desire tree and asks for a child. Parvati's wish for a daughter is granted, and Ashokasundari, a beautiful girl is born. Ashokasundari grows up kind, brave and gentle. She has no interest in marrying, but she is destined to marry Prince Nahusha. Hunda gets angry and tries to kill Nahusha. However, fate protects Nahusha and when he grows up, he defeats the demon. Finally, Ashokasundari marries Nahusha. It teaches love, courage, faith and the bond of a mother and her daughter.

Analysis: In this story Parvati's love creates Ashokasundari, showcasing maternal love's power and divine justice. Good triumphs as Ashokasundari and Nahusha's love prevails, highlighting faith and courage.

4.4 YATRA NARYASTU PUJYANTE RAMANTE TATRA DEVATA

4.4.1 The Maiden of the River: In this short story the river Ganga, is considered to be the feminine gender it is one of the most sacred river. It flows from the Himalayas and it is considered to be a holy river. Long back ago, King named Bhagiratha prayed for many years so that Ganga could come down from the heavens to the earth. He wanted the river to wash away the ashes of his ancestors so their souls could rest peacefully. When Ganga first came down, her water fell with great force that could destroy everything. To protect the earth, Lord Shiva caught her in his hair and let her water flow gently on the land. As she moved across the land, Ganga helped many people. She met sages and ordinary people who believed her water could wash away their sadness and sins. One sage named Jahnu once drank all the water to stop flooding, and later Ganga came out of his ears, so she was also called Jahnvi. Ganga is described like a caring and loving woman who brings peace and hope to everyone. People still worship her and think bathing in her water makes them pure and good. The story shows why Ganga is respected, loved, and connected deeply with human life and culture.

Analysis: This short story shows how Ganga shows her sacred nature and also teaches that purity, faith, and devotion bring peace, hope, and cleansing of sins to people.

4.4.2 The Perfect Revenge: This story begins with a beautiful woman named Shurpanakha the sister of the powerful king Ravana of Lanka. When she grew up, she fell in love with a prince from a different clan of Asura. She was knowing that her brother would not approve, so she married him secretly. When Ravana discovered their marriage, he became very angry and wanted to punish her. But his wife Mandodari encouraged him to respect his sister's choice, so he finally accepted both of them as husband and wife. However, Viduyjyihva his hidden plans, he married her only to get close to Ravana and kill him. One day, Ravana went to his sister's place to visit her new home, but his sister was not there at home. The prince took the opportunity and tries to attack him, but the Ravana defeats and kills him. Shurpanakha is shocked and heartbroken. She became a widow at very young age and this incident created a misunderstanding among them. She believed that Ravana never really accepted her marriage and he is responsible for her husband's death. So she went with anger and pain into the forest. She plans carefully and uses her

intelligence. Time passed and her hurt turns into a strong desire for revenge. One day when Shurpanakha was on the banks of the river Godavari in Panchavati today it is called as Nashik. There she saw Rama the prince of Ayodhya and falls him when she approached Rama and confessed her love towards him, he rejected her. After going back begin insulted she saw Rama's wife Sita. Shurpanakha found her as a beautiful. Knowing Ravana's weakness for beautiful women, Shurpanakha went to her brother and described Sita's unique beauty making him curious. This leads Ravana to abduct Sita. This kidnaping made it certain which starts a great war. That Rama would neither forgive Ravana. He was sure to kill Ravana and he did and it become the perfect Revenge for Shurpanakha

Analysis-This story shows how Shurpanakha's pain and anger changed her completely. Because she wanted revenge it caused a war that destroyed everything

4.4.3 The Frog Who Forgot Happiness: Once there lived a group of wise sages who were very much at peace. Every day, they would go to their temple, and every evening they would return home. They sustained themselves by eating fruits from the trees and drinking water out of a local well. A frog lived inside that well, secretly observing the sages' pious behavior from his hiding place. One day when the sages had gone away to do their daily religious duties, a snake slithered into the well where the frogs were at and poisoned all of the water in the well. The frog jumped into the poisoned water to try and help the sages before they were able to return home to drink the illegal water. The frog died immediately after hitting the water. Upon returning from their daily worship, the sages found that the body of the frog had turned blue. After using their powers as masters of yoga, they resurrected the frog so that they might grant him a wish. The frog wished to be beautiful and marry a great king. He would later become Mandodari, the daughter of Mayasura, and marry Ravana but forget to ask for happiness. As a consequence, she had no joy in life.

Analysis: This story teaches that true happiness doesn't come from beauty or power, but it comes from inner joy, purpose, and wise choices in life.

4.4.4 The Goddess of the White Lake: This story talks about the King Bharata he ruled the kingdom of Ayodhya and his younger brother Bahubali got Podanapur. Bharata was one of the hundred sons of the first Tirthankara. One day, he found a magical spinning disc in his palace. The wise men told him that this disc was a sign that he could become a great emperor. But to achieve this, all his brothers had to accept him as their king. Most of his brothers agreed peacefully. However, Bahubali, refused to give up his kingdom as he was brave and strong. He did not want a war that would harm innocent people, so he suggested that they will fight with each others alone. They had three contests: wrestling, a water fight, and a staring contest. Bahubali won and defeated Bharata. But after winning, Bahubali did not feel happy. He understood that power and pride were meaningless. So, he gave up his kingdom and became a monk. He stood in deep meditation for a long time. Later, Bharata felt sorry and went to meet him. At that moment, Bahubali achieved moksha, freedom from rebirth. A huge statue was built in his honor. Later, an old woman showed that true devotion and faith are more powerful than pride and wealth. The story teaches us that humility and peace are greater than power.

Analysis: This story teaches us that true strength lies in peace and humility, not in power, and faith and devotion matter more than pride.

4.4.5 The Secret of Youth: This story is about Princess called Sukanya, the daughter of King Sharyati. One day the king went for hunting his daughter also accompanied him with her friends, while walking in the forest, she saw a strange white anthill with two shining spots. Out of curiosity, she poked them with a stick. She did not know that a sage named Chyavana was meditating inside. Her action injured his eyes and made him blind. The angry sage cursed the king's army. They began to suffer greatly. When the king learned the reason, he asked the sage for forgiveness. Chyavana said he would remove the curse only if Sukanya married him. To save everyone, Sukanya agreed and became his wife. Later, the Ashwini Kumars, the divine healers, offered to make the old sage young again. After a special treatment, Chyavana became handsome and youthful. Sukanya's true love helped her recognize him. The story teaches us about sacrifice, loyalty, love, and inner beauty.

Analysis: Princess Sukanya shows us that true love and loyalty, teaching us that caring for others and staying devoted is more important than looks or wealth.

4.4.6 The Princess and the Ugly Dwarf: Sudha Murty narrates an Indian mythological story through her work *The Princess and the Ugly Dwarf* which shows that appearances should not be used as a basis for making judgments about others. The story revolves around a princess who possesses extraordinary beauty which creates universal admiration among all people. Many people praise her looks, and she becomes proud of how she appears. One day, she meets a dwarf who is not good-looking. People treat him poorly because he looks different from them, so they laugh at him. The dwarf possesses a good heart and pure intentions. He shows respect to the princess through his honest and polite conduct. The princess first dismisses him because she only sees his outer appearance. Through various experiences, she starts to observe his wisdom and loyalty and virtuous nature. She discovers that true beauty exists beyond physical appearance and resides in a person's character and their actions. The princess discovers an essential lesson about humility and kindness at the conclusion of the story. The story teaches readers that we should not judge anyone by their looks. True beauty exists in people who possess both a good heart and positive behavior and inner strength.

Analysis: This story shows that True beauty comes from kindness, loyalty, and good character, not just from looks, this book teaches us to value people for who they are.

4.4.7 The Princess Who Became a Wedding Gift: This tale is about Devayani, the lovely princess, who is the daughter of Shukracharya, the teacher of the asuras. The gods and asuras were always at war. The asuras had the upper hand because Shukracharya knew a special mantra called Sanjeevani, which had the power to revive the dead. To acquire this knowledge, the gods sent Kacha, the son of Brihaspati, to learn from Shukracharya. Kacha lived in the ashram and was a devoted student of his teacher. During this period, Devayani fell in love with him. The asuras were jealous of Kacha and killed him several times, but each time Shukracharya revived him. One time, Kacha was killed and mixed with Shukracharya's body. To save his life, Shukracharya taught him the mantra. Kacha was revived and also brought his teacher back to life. When Devayani asked Kacha to marry her, he refused, saying he looked upon her as a sister. Devayani was

heartbroken and furious and cursed him. Later, Devayani married King Yayati. But Yayati also married her friend Sharmishtha secretly. When Devayani discovered this, she asked her father to curse Yayati, making him old. In the end, Yayati learned that endless desire never brings true happiness.

Analysis: The story shows love, jealousy, ego, and desire, teaching us that selfish choices and anger always bring pain and regret

4.4.8 Two Stars of True Love: This story is about Arundhati and her husband, Sage Vasishtha. Arundhati was intelligent and loved learning. After marriage, she continued studying and even helped Vasishtha in teaching. She proved that she was as wise and capable as her husband. Seeing their goodness, Brahma gifted them a magical cow named Nandini to help them in their daily work. One day, King Vishvamitra visited their ashram. He became jealous of their magical cow and tried to take it by force. But he failed and later realized that true power comes from knowledge, not wealth or force. When Vasishtha went away for penance, Arundhati stayed alone and bravely faced a famine. She cared for a young boy and taught him with kindness. Later, the boy revealed himself as Lord Shiva and blessed her devotion. In the end, Arundhati and Vasishtha were honored in the sky as stars. Their story teaches love, equality, wisdom, and true partnership in marriage.

Analysis: The story teaches that equality in marriage, value of knowledge, true devotion, kindness, and that real strength comes from compassion.

4.4.9 The Curse of Immortality: In this tale, there were two sages named Nara and Narayana who were performing deep meditation in the Himalayas. Their concentration alarmed Indra, the king of the gods, who feared their power. To divert their attention, he sent beautiful apsaras (celestial dancers) with the assistance of the god of love, but the sages did not waver in their concentration. In anger at being spurned, Narayana created a maiden named Urvashi, who was loved for her beauty and granted immortality. Indra desired Urvashi in his heavenly kingdom, but she had a mortal heart and yearned for real love. In the course of a dance performance, she inadvertently declared her love for a mortal king named Pururava instead of a god. For this reason, she was cursed to live on earth as a mortal. Urvashi decided to remain with her husband and braved many

difficulties, sacrificing her immortal life and even her son in order to make Pururava happy. Ultimately, her love and sacrifices proved that true devotion can be more powerful than immortality itself.

Analysis: The story shows that eternal life is not happiness, and true love, sacrifice, and human connection are more meaningful than immortality.

4.4.10 The First Clone in the World: Sanjana is the beautiful daughter of Vishwakarma, the divine craftsman in the story “The First Clone in the World”. Her father wants her to marry a powerful god who will bring light and goodness in her life. After much consideration, Sanjana selects Surya, the sun god, whose bright warmth seems ideally suited to her life. She at first takes delight in her choice but later realizes that the heat from Surya is unbearable on a daily basis. Even after her father works to diminish some of the god’s power, she still feels discomfort. To solve this problem, Sanjana uses her father’s knowledge and creates a clone of herself – another Sanjana who can live with Surya without feeling discomfort. She names her clone Chaya and sends her to stay with Surya. Chaya eventually joins Surya and gives birth to Shani, who later becomes the god associated with the planet Saturn. The story Sanjana marks the first person to think and create a human clone in the mythology story line.

Analysis: The story shows us creativity solving problems and teaches that intelligence and courage can find new solutions, even in difficult or unusual situations.

4.4.11 The Seven Fierce Mothers: Seven Fierce Mothers The Saptamatrikas represent seven mother goddesses who establish their worship through the multiple temples which exist throughout South India. The Chola period temples display their sacred statues which remain visible to visitors. The seven mothers are Brahmi, Vaishnavi, Kaatyayini, Indrani, Kaumari, Varahi, and Chamunda. Each goddess possesses her own unique weapon and vehicle while displaying divine attributes which demonstrate her power. The ancient legends contain the story about these mothers. A strange problem emerged during the battle which Lord Shiva fought against the demon Andhakasura. The demon blood produced new demons with every drop that fell from him. The seven mothers existed to assist Shiva in stopping this situation from happening. The brave warriors consumed the

demon blood which prevented additional demons from being born. Shiva used their assistance to achieve victory over the demon. The Saptamatrikas represent the combination of bravery and collaborative strength which women possess. The common people worship them as protective forces who eliminate evil while providing their worshippers with increased strength.

Analysis: Women possess strength through their ability to create unity which empowers them to face challenges together as a team. The collective power of their group enables them to overcome even the most powerful evil forces.

4.4.12 The Weight of a Leaf: The story begins with the beautiful tree Called Parijata , a special tree that came from the churning of the ocean and was planted in the garden of Indra. The flowers of this tree are very fragrant and rare. Krishna and his wife Satyabhama visit Indra's garden, and Satyabhama becomes enchanted by the tree. She wants a branch of the Parijata tree for their home, but Krishna tells her not to ask too much from Indra. Later, Indra sends some of the flowers as a gift to Krishna, but they are given to Krishna's other wife, Rukmini, which makes Satyabhama jealous. Satyabhama then asks Krishna to take the Parijata tree to their garden. Indra agrees but warns that the tree will favor Rukmini's side. Once planted, the Parijata tree leans toward Rukmini's garden, making Satyabhama more jealous. Feeling proud and angry, Satyabhama promises the sage Narada that she will give Krishna as a gift. Krishna becomes Narada's servant, but Satyabhama later regrets her words and wants Krishna back. Narada asks her to give gold equal to Krishna's weight, but even all her wealth cannot balance the scale. Finally, Rukmini offers a single tulsi leaf placed on the scale with devotion, and miraculously it balances Krishna's weight. This teaches Satyabhama that true love and devotion are more important than pride or wealth.

Analysis: This story shows us real love and devotion matter more than wealth or pride, and jealousy can hide true feelings.

4.4.13 The Temple Without a Deity: The plot of this story presents a tribal chief named Viswavasu who worshipped the powerful deity Nila Madhava at a secret shrine located in Odisha. King Indradyumna who lived nearby wanted to transport the sacred god to his

realm. Viswavasus denied him access to the sacred location which contained the hidden god. The brother of the king named Vidyapati disguised himself as a priest to win the trust of Viswavasus's daughter by marrying her. Yet he still remained unable to discover the concealed deity. Viswavasus finally permitted Vidyapati to visit the cave while he blindfolded him. Vidyapati used mustard seeds to trace their route which later grew into plants that directed the king toward their destination. The statue was transported to Puri but when King Indradyumna visited the site the deity vanished from sight. The celestial voice instructed the king to request assistance from Vishwakarma who functions as the divine architect. Vishwakarma accepted the request to create new statues but requested a period of solitude to execute his task. The king opened the doors prematurely because of his excessive curiosity which resulted in the statues being incomplete and missing their hands. The story shows that respect and patience together with dedication to God which takes precedence over physical perfection lead to more valuable outcomes than material ownership.

Analysis: The story shows that true devotion and respect for divinity matter more than power or wealth because it requires people to demonstrate their patience and humility while they trust God.

4.4.14 Soldiers in the Elephant's Stomach: In the story "Soldiers in the Elephant's Stomach," we have King Udayana, who is a young and kind ruler of the kingdom of Vatsadesha. He prefers music to war, particularly playing the veena. His chief minister, Yaugandharayana, is very wise and advises him about the kings in the surrounding kingdoms who are planning to trick him. One such king is Pradyota of Avanti, whose daughter Vasavadatta is famous for her beauty and elegance. Pradyota asks Udayana to marry his daughter, but he has a very peculiar plan to get what he wants. Pradyota constructs a massive elephant model and puts his soldiers inside it. There are rumors about the dangerous nature of the elephant. Hearing this, Udayana goes to the forest to play music, unaware of the trick. The soldiers inside the elephant model capture him and take him to Pradyota. What happens next is a combination of clever planning, the development of respect between the two kings, and the initiation of a deep relationship between Udayana and Vasavadatta.

Analysis: The story indicates that trickery can be overcome by courage, cleverness, and love, and that wisdom is as valuable as strength in life.

4.4.15 The Forgotten Wife: In short story The Forgotten Wife, we meet Vachaspati Mishra, a very wise and hardworking scholar from ancient Mithila who dreams of writing an important book about the Vedanta. He believes marriage will take his focus away, but his mother finds him a bride named Bhamati, who agrees to marry him understanding his goals. After marriage, Vachaspati becomes so busy with his work that he barely notices Bhamati's presence. Bhamati quietly takes care of his needs, cooks his food, helps him study, and supports him every day. Year's pass, and Vachaspati completes his great book, but only then does he realize how much Bhamati has done for him. He has never truly appreciated her love and sacrifices. Feeling ashamed, he names his book "Bhamati" in her honor to show how important she was in his success. The story shows that behind every great person, there is often someone whose help is quietly forgotten.

Analysis: The story teaches that true love and support often go unnoticed and we should value and appreciate those who help us quietly.

Through all these stories, Sudha Murty highlights those women are not weak or secondary figures. They instruct families, influence decisions, protect the universe and shape destiny. Some fight openly, while others silently support those around them. Each character holds a moral lesson that is still relevant today.

Overall, the book explores womanhood and memorize readers that woman have always been strong and meaningful figures in mythology and life. It boosts respect for woman and teaches timeless values such as presenting these stories in simple and captivating language. By presenting these stories in simple and captivating language, the author makes ancient mythology meaningful and inspiring for modern readers

CHAPTER 5: ANALYSIS AND CONCLUSION

Ancient Indian mythological texts like the *Shiv Purana*, *Vishnu Purana*, the *Mahabharata*, and the *Ramayana* occupy a sacred place in Hindu tradition. The *Shiv Purana*, written in Sanskrit, presents Lord Shiva as the supreme cosmic force and explores profound spiritual and philosophical ideas. Its language, symbolism, and theological depth often make it difficult for common readers, especially younger generations, to fully understand. The same can be said about the *Vishnu Purana*, the *Mahabharata*, and the *Ramayana*. These texts focus on divine authority, cosmic order, karma, dharma, and spiritual liberation. They are deeply religious and philosophical, and therefore not always easily accessible to modern readers.

Sudha Murty, in her retellings, takes these grand and sacred narratives and reshapes them for contemporary society. She moves away from complex theological explanations and instead focuses on storytelling. Her language is simple, clear, and direct. She writes in English so that present and upcoming generations can understand the stories without difficulty. While the original texts emphasize divine supremacy and ritual importance, Sudha Murty emphasizes morals, human values, and practical lessons for daily life. In doing so, she makes mythology relatable and meaningful for modern readers.

One of the major strengths of her retellings is simplicity. Stories such as “The Indra Who Became the Pandavas,” “The Legend of the Elephants,” “The Elephant Demon,” “The Half Man, the Half Woman,” “The Girl That God Took,” and “The Story of Adi Shankara” are narrated in a very straightforward manner. For example, the story of the half-man and half-woman form of Shiva (Ardhanarishvara) is not presented merely as a religious symbol. Instead, it is explained as a powerful idea of balance, unity, and gender equality. Through such storytelling, she connects mythology with present-day conversations about identity and equality.

Similarly, from the Vishnu tradition, she includes episodes such as “The Invincible Princes,” “The God with the Head of a Horse,” “The Churning of the Ocean,” “The Ten

Avatars,” “A Friend in Need,” and “The Three Mortal Lifetimes.” These stories are simplified and presented as meaningful narratives rather than complicated theological discourses. Even in stories like “Brahma’s Folly,” where Brahma makes a mistake, Sudha Murty shows that even higher authorities are not free from errors. They too must face the consequences of their actions. This idea fits well with the modern democratic mindset, where even powerful individuals are held accountable.

Sudha Murty also includes several episodes from the Mahabharata. In “The Steps to Heaven,” she speaks about Kunti and the Gajagauri Puja performed for her children’s welfare, a practice that is still followed in Karnataka. By connecting mythology with living traditions, she shows how ancient stories continue to influence present society. In another story, “The Way You Look at It,” she presents a conversation between Karna and Krishna as if they are ordinary human beings discussing their struggles. Both feel that the other person’s life might be better. This humanizes divine and heroic characters, making them emotionally relatable. The gods and heroes are not distant, untouchable figures; they experience doubt, pain, and confusion just like common people.

From the Ramayana, she retells the story titled “The Perfect Revenge,” focusing on Surpanakha and Ravana. Instead of presenting Surpanakha only as a villain, Sudha Murty explains her background and emotions. She describes how Surpanakha, feels humiliated when Lakshmana cuts off her nose. Her actions that follow are driven by hurt and revenge. By narrating the episode in this way, Sudha Murty invites readers to think about emotions, consequences, and human reactions rather than simply labeling characters as good or evil.

A significant aspect of her writing is that she shifts the focus from ritual to relatability. She reconstructs stories by understanding today’s society. Instead of emphasizing strict religious rules, she highlights universal values such as kindness, humility, equality, and responsibility. Her stories echo contemporary conversations about gender equality, moral responsibility, and human dignity. They also beautifully portray relationships such as the mother-son bond, the guru-shishya bond, and the importance of friendship and loyalty.

Moral values are central to most of her stories. In “A Simple Life,” the story of the sage Kaushika teaches that true wisdom comes from humility and righteous action. Kaushika is

proud of his spiritual power, believing he can burn anyone to ashes. However, a simple housewife corrects him and shows him that spiritual strength without humility is meaningless. This story teaches that inner greatness is earned through good deeds, not through pride or anger. It also highlights that moral strength can exist in ordinary people, not only in sages or learned men.

Another example is “The Order of a Guru,” which narrates the story of Dhaumya and his disciple Upamanyu. The disciple obeys his guru even during hardships. Through this story, Sudha Murty emphasizes patience, faith, dedication, and respect. She shows that true devotion and discipline eventually lead to wisdom and success. These stories are written in a child-friendly manner so that young readers can easily understand and remember the lessons.

Female characters are also given importance in her retellings. In “A Simple Life,” the brave housewife stands firm before the proud sage and guides him toward the right path. She is not afraid of his power because she believes in her own righteousness. This shows that moral courage is not limited by gender. In the story of Sati, she chooses Shiva as her husband despite her father’s opposition. Her determination and loyalty are highlighted. Though her decision leads to tragic consequences, Sudha Murty presents her as a woman with agency and choice. Through such portrayals, she brings women to the center of the narrative rather than keeping them in the background.

Another important feature of Sudha Murty’s retelling is the dehumanization of the divine in one sense and the humanization in another. While she removes excessive ritualistic grandeur, she also makes divinity accessible to everyone. The divine is no longer limited to scholars, priests, or powerful sages. It becomes something that ordinary people can understand and connect with. This democratization of the divine removes barriers of caste, gender, and rigid interpretation that are sometimes associated with ancient texts.

She also emphasizes that pride leads to downfall. Many of her stories show that arrogance, whether in gods, sages, or kings, results in consequences. Even higher authorities are not exempt from mistakes. This moral principle aligns with modern values

where accountability is essential. Her storytelling method ensures that readers learn about responsibility, empathy, and self-reflection.

In conclusion, Sudha Murty's reimagining of mythology successfully bridges the gap between ancient scriptures and modern readers. While the original Sanskrit texts focus on theology, cosmic order, and ritual, her retellings focus on storytelling, human emotions, and moral lessons. She moves from ritual to relatability. By reconstructing stories in simple English, she makes them accessible, inclusive, and meaningful for present and future generations.

Her narratives encourage curiosity and continuous reading because they are clear and engaging. She does not dilute the essence of mythology but reshapes it to suit contemporary understanding. Through her work, mythology becomes not just a sacred text to be worshipped, but a living guide for ethical and balanced living. Thus, her select works truly represent a thoughtful and meaningful reimagining of Indian mythology for the modern world.

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